# HISTORICAL WEBSITE FOOTPRINTING

Historical Website Data Collection and Passive OSINT Using the Internet Archive

**Project domain:** stayzilla.com

**Primary source:** Internet Archive / Wayback Machine

Prepared as a cybersecurity research portfolio project

Project status: This document provides the workflow and evidence-recording structure. Complete the evidence inventory with the archived URLs, capture dates, screenshots, and observations you personally collected before presenting the analysis as finished.

# 1. Introduction

Websites can change, become inactive, or disappear from ordinary search results. Historical web archives preserve snapshots of some pages and resources, allowing researchers to study what was publicly available at a particular time. Such records are useful for digital history, organizational research, and passive cybersecurity reconnaissance. An archive is not a complete copy of a website: pages, images, scripts, and links may be missing or incomplete.

# 2. Aim and Objectives

- Locate available historical captures of stayzilla.com in the Wayback Machine.
- Record complete archived URLs and capture dates so that each observation can be reproduced.
- Preserve screenshots of relevant archived pages and label each file consistently.
- Compare accessible snapshots and describe observable changes in content or layout.
- Explain how archived information can support passive open-source intelligence (OSINT) research.
- Document gaps, uncertainty, and limitations without making unsupported claims about vulnerabilities.

# 3. Tools and Sources

| Tool / source | Purpose |
|---|---|
| Internet Archive | Non-profit digital library hosting archived web material. |
| Wayback Machine | Search and view available historical captures for a domain or URL. |
| Web browser / screenshots | Review pages and preserve visual evidence of the selected capture. |
| Spreadsheet or CSV (optional) | Record capture dates, URLs, page titles, and observations consistently. |

# 4. Methodology

**Step 1 — Define the target. Record the organization name and domain selected for this project: Stayzilla / stayzilla.com.**

**Step 2 — Search the archive.** Open the Wayback Machine calendar for the domain and identify available captures, especially those around 2017 and any other dates relevant to the research question.

**Step 3 — Open a specific capture.** Select a calendar date and record the complete archived URL shown in the browser address bar.

**Step 4 — Capture evidence.** Take screenshots that show the relevant page and, where possible, the archived URL/date. Avoid cropping out context needed to verify the source.

**Step 5 — Log the record.** For each screenshot, record the snapshot date, archived URL, page type/title if visible, and a short factual observation.

**Step 6 — Compare captures.** Compare snapshots only where both captures are accessible. Describe visible differences (for example, page layout or text) and avoid inferring why a change occurred unless a source supports it.

**Step 7 — Preserve provenance.** Keep original screenshots and record the date on which the archive was accessed. Clearly distinguish archived content from present-day information.

# 5. Evidence Inventory (complete with your actual data)

| Evidence ID | Archived URL | Capture date | Screenshot filename | Observation |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| E-01 | [https://web.archive.org/web/20110415000000*/https://stayzilla.com/] | [2011-10-00] | [E-01_Wayback_Calendar_Overview.png] | Wayback Machine calendar showing 347 saved captures for Stayzilla..] |
| E-02 | [https://web.archive.org/web/20111026235702/https://stayzilla.com/#home] | [2011-10-26] | [E-02_Stayzilla_Homepage.png] | Describe the information visible on the archived About Us page. |
| E-03 | [https://web.archive.org/web/20170928233633/https://www.stayzilla.com/] | [2017-10-20] | [E-03_Stayzilla_Homestay_Search.png] | The archived page displays a homestay search interface with destination, check-in, check-out, and traveller fields. The tourism partner section contains several images that do not appear to have loaded. |

# 6. Findings and Analysis

Complete this section using the screenshots and archived URLs collected during the project. For each record, state what the evidence directly shows and include the relevant capture date. The specific screenshots and URLs are not embedded in this draft, so it does not make claims about exact page content, the number of captures, specific website changes, exposed data, or vulnerabilities.

For each evidence item, describe: (1) what page is visible; (2) its archived capture date; (3) observable text or design elements; (4) differences from another dated capture, if compared; and (5) any missing content or loading errors. Keep interpretations separate from direct observations.

# 7. Cybersecurity Relevance

Historical website analysis can help an analyst understand an organization's former public-facing content and

digital footprint. In a cybersecurity workflow, it may support passive reconnaissance and help frame questions for authorized assessments. Archived content is historical context, not proof of a current weakness. This project does not attempt unauthorized access, exploitation, credential collection, or intrusive scanning.

# 8. Limitations and Ethical Considerations

- The archive may not have captured every page or asset.
- Some archived links may fail or redirect.
- Capture timestamps represent archive records and may not show when the content was first published.
- Archived material may contain outdated or personal information; avoid republishing sensitive data unnecessarily.
- Do not claim a domain is currently offline or expired without a separate, current verification.
- Use screenshots and excerpts in a way that respects privacy, copyright, and applicable rules.

# 9. Conclusion

This project outlines a repeatable process for examining historical website records through the Internet Archive. Recording archived URLs, capture dates, screenshots, and factual observations creates a transparent evidence trail and allows accessible snapshots to be compared over time. Before publication, complete the evidence inventory, add the collected screenshots, and ensure that each finding is supported by a specific archived record.

# 10. References

1. Internet Archive, official website: https://archive.org/

2. Wayback Machine: https://web.archive.org/

3. Wayback Machine target calendar for stayzilla.com: https://web.archive.org/web/*/stayzilla.com